

European Politics (Spring 2026)

Joint Course between Bocconi and IE University

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1. Suggested background knowledge

Prior coursework in political science, international relations or European history would be helpful but not mandatory.

2. Course mission & content summary

This joint course has been developed within the framework of CIVICA, an alliance of ten leading European higher education Institutions in the social sciences co-funded by the European Union under the Erasmus+ programme. The mission of this course is to introduce students to European politics and current debates in European integration. The substantive material mostly covers the functioning of the European Union. The course will draw on cutting edge research from different areas of European politics to understand some of the most important challenges that European policymaking faces today (such as enlargement, security concerns, Euroscepticism, political fragmentation, and the limits of technocratic government).

The course introduces students to a basic toolkit used by researchers of international interdependence to understand politics at the EU level, and their interplay with national politics as well. The material to be covered relates both to the historical development of European integration, and to contemporary challenges. As might be expected for topics as broad and complex as these, while there is much we currently know, many debates are still open. The objective of this course is to weigh the available evidence to arrive at the fullest possible understanding of key themes within European politics today.

3. Intended Learning Outcomes (ILO)

Knowledge and understanding

- summarize the key theories trying to understand and explain democratic delegation and multilevel politics in Europe;
- describe the institutional structure, policy-making and electoral politics of the EU;
- explain the most important challenges that national and EU institutions and policy-making face today.

Applying knowledge and understanding

- apply the theoretical and empirical insights presented during the course to assess and interpret the behaviour of political actors in Europe through the theoretical lenses of democratic delegation and multilevel politics;
- use the theoretical and empirical insights presented during the course to discuss the key political challenges and risks facing the EU and its member states.
- connect the theoretical and empirical insights presented during the course to develop policy scenarios that allow for insights into how to address some of these key political challenges and risks in the future.

4. Teaching methods

Lectures will be structured according to the standard format: the instructor will present and elaborate on the material contained in the required readings, which the students will have read before class, so as to enhance in-class discussions and students' participation. In order to facilitate a deeper understanding of the lecture materials, students will agree with the instructor a case study to prepare as a presentation and/or as a response to other students' presentations.

5. Assessment methods

Attending students (i.e., those attending at least 70% of classes)

Student assessment is based on three components:

- **Exam (60% of final grade):** The exam is based on a mix of multiple-choice and open questions. Multiple choice questions and open-ended questions will be designed to test the students' knowledge of all the material covered in the course, excluding the case studies (i.e., excluding readings listed under 'Indicative preparation material').
- **Case study presentation (30% of final grade):** The case study is designed to apply the theories and readings to real-world events. Registered students—in teams blending Bocconi and IE students—must give one presentation on a case study that applies the week's required reading and relate it to a practical situation in European politics. Readings and/or media content is provided to introduce students to the topics of the case study, but further research is required. The presentations will be allocated at the beginning of the semester. Students present during the class. The presentations should last approx. 20 minutes. The presentations should be intellectually stimulating—don't be boring!
- **Response presentation (10% of final grade):** Another team of students—again blending Bocconi and IE students—will shortly (5-8 minutes) respond to the main presentation. This should include alternative explanations for the phenomenon, additional evidence that presents a more nuanced picture, questions for the main presenters, and open questions for the classroom.

Non-attending students

Exam (100% of final grade): The exam is based on a mix of multiple-choice and open questions. Multiple choice questions and open-ended questions will be designed to test the students' knowledge of all the material covered in the course.

Course Content

Date	Session content	Readings
Fri 6/2/2026 08:30 -10:00	Introduction	Napolitano, Giorgio. 2019. "The Fundamental Goal of the European Project," in Amato, Giuliano, et al., eds. <i>The History of the European Union: Constructing Utopia</i> . Hart.
Fri 6/2/2026 10:15 – 11:45	The functioning of the EU	Hix, Simon, and Bjørn Høyland. 2022. <i>The Political System of the European Union</i> . Bloomsbury Academic. [CHAPTER 2]
Fri 13/2/2026 08:30 -10:00	Theories of European integration	Hooghe, Liesbet, and Gary Marks. 2019. "Grand Theories of European Integration in the Twenty-First Century." <i>Journal of European Public Policy</i> 26 (8): 1113–33.
Fri 13/2/2026 10:15 – 11:45	Case study: How technocratic is the EU?	Indicative preparation material: - Georgakakis, Didier. 2013. "What Is Happening to the Staff of European Institutions?: A Cross-Disciplinary View." In <i>Routledge Handbook of International Organization</i>, edited by Bob Reinalda. Routledge. - Egeberg, Morten, Åse Gornitzka, and Jarle Trondal. 2014. "A Not So Technocratic Executive? Everyday Interaction between the European Parliament and the Commission." <i>West European Politics</i> 37 (1): 1–18. - Sánchez-Cuenca, Ignacio. 2017. "From a Deficit of Democracy to a Technocratic Order: The Postcrisis Debate on Europe." <i>Annual Review of Political Science</i> 20 : 351–69. - Scicluna, Nicole, and Stefan Auer. 2019. "From the Rule of Law to the Rule of Rules: Technocracy and the Crisis of EU Governance." <i>West European Politics</i> 42 (7): 1420–42.
Fri 20/2/2026 08:30 -10:00	Democracy in the EU	De Vries, Catherine E., and Alexandros Kentikelenis. 2026. <i>How Europe Survives: The Adaptability and Resilience of a Continent in Peril</i> . Oxford University Press. [CHAPTER 6]
Fri 20/2/2026 10:15 – 11:45	Case study: Is there a democratic deficit?	Indicative preparation material: - Majone, Giandomenico. 1998. "Europe's 'Democratic Deficit': The Question of Standards." <i>European Law Journal</i> 4 (1): 5–28. - Moravcsik, Andrew. 2002. "In Defence of the 'Democratic Deficit': Reassessing Legitimacy in the European Union." <i>JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies</i> 40 (4): 603–24. - Follesdal, Andreas, and Simon Hix. 2006. "Why There Is a Democratic Deficit in the EU: A Response to Majone and Moravcsik." <i>JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies</i> 44 (3): 533–62.

		• Moravcsik, Andrew. 2008. "The Myth of Europe's Democratic Deficit." <i>Intereconomics</i> 43 (6): 331–40.
Fri 27/2/2026 08:30 -10:00	European economic integration	Caporaso, James A., Min-hyung Kim, Warren N. Durrett, and Richard B. Wesley. 2015. "Still a Regulatory State? The European Union and the Financial Crisis." <i>Journal of European Public Policy</i> 22 (7): 889–907.
Fri 27/2/2026 10:15 – 11:45	Case study: Handling the Eurozone crisis	Indicative preparation material: • Copelovitch, Mark, Jeffry Frieden, and Stefanie Walter. 2016. "The Political Economy of the Euro Crisis." <i>Comparative Political Studies</i> 49 (7): 811–40. • Woodruff, David M. 2016. "Governing by Panic: The Politics of the Eurozone Crisis." <i>Politics & Society</i> 44 (1): 81–116. • Carstensen, Martin B., and Vivien A. Schmidt. 2018. "Power and Changing Modes of Governance in the Euro Crisis." <i>Governance</i> 31 (4): 609–24. • Schmidt, Vivien A. 2020. <i>Europe's Crisis of Legitimacy: Governing by Rules and Ruling by Numbers in the Eurozone</i>. Oxford University Press. • Miró, Joan. 2021. "Austerity's Failures and Policy Learning: Mapping European Commission Officials' Beliefs on Fiscal Governance in the Post-Crisis EU." <i>Review of International Political Economy</i> 28 (5): 1224–48.
Fri 6/3/2026 08:30 -10:00	Europe's economic governance at crossroads	Notermans, Ton, and Simona Piattoni. 2025. "From Ordo-Liberalism to Ordo-Keynesianism? The Contradictory Nature of EU Economic Governance." <i>Journal of European Integration</i> 47 (8): 1305–26.
Tue 10/3/2026 08:30 -10:00	Case study: Europe's economic governance at crossroads	Indicative preparation material: • Bokhorst, David, and Francesco Corti. 2024. "Governing Europe's Recovery and Resilience Facility: Between Discipline and Discretion." <i>Government and Opposition</i> 59 (3): 718–34. • Buti, Marco, and Sergio Fabbrini. 2023. "Next Generation EU and the Future of Economic Governance: Towards a Paradigm Change or Just a Big One-Off?" <i>Journal of European Public Policy</i> 30 (4): 676–95. • Georgiou, Christakis. 2025. "The Structural Power of Finance, the Quest for EU Safe Assets and the Prospect of a Permanent EU Borrowing Capacity." <i>Journal of European Public Policy</i>, December 28, 1–26. • Vanhercke, Bart, and Amy Verdun. 2022. "The European Semester as Goldilocks: Macroeconomic Policy Coordination and the Recovery and Resilience Facility." <i>JCMS: Journal of Common Market Studies</i> 60 (1): 204–23.

		Zeitlin, Jonathan, David Bokhorst, and Edgars Eihmanis. 2025. "Governing the European Union's Recovery and Resilience Facility: National Ownership and Performance-Based Financing in Theory and Practice." <i>Regulation & Governance</i> 19 (3): 864–84.
Fri 13/3/2026 08:30 -10:00	Europe's social model	De Vries, Catherine E., and Alexandros Kentikelenis. 2026. <i>How Europe Survives: The Adaptability and Resilience of a Continent in Peril</i> . Oxford University Press. [CHAPTER 5]
Fri 13/3/2026 10:15 – 11:45	Case study: the EU role in social policy	Indicative preparation material: - Offe, Claus. 2003. "The European Model of 'Social' Capitalism: Can It Survive European Integration?" <i>Journal of Political Philosophy</i> 11 (4): 437–69. - Scharpf, F. W. 2010. "The Asymmetry of European Integration, or Why the EU Cannot Be a 'Social Market Economy.'" <i>Socio-Economic Review</i> 8 (2): 211–50. - Hemerijck, Anton, and Manos Matsaganis. 2024. <i>Who's Afraid of the Welfare State Now?</i> Oxford University Press. [CHAPTERS 3 AND 8]
Fri 17/4/2026 08:30 -10:00	The EU's Twin Transition: Climate and Digital	Muñoz-de-Bustillo Llorente, R. (2024). <i>A critical review of the digital and green twin transitions: Implications, synergies and trade-offs</i> (JRC Working Papers Series on Labour, Education and Technology No. 2024/07; JRC140036). European Commission, Joint Research Centre.
Fri 17/4/2026 10:15 – 11:45	Case Study: The Green transition and Euroscepticism	Indicative Preparation Material: - Toygür, I., & Sojka, A. (2026). Does climate policy backlash fuel Eurosceptic vote? Exploring the link in the European Parliament elections. <i>Journal of European Public Policy</i>, 33(2), 528–554. - Jones, E., & Youngs, R. (2025, September 11). <i>Confronting backlash against Europe's green transition</i>. Carnegie Endowment for International Peace. https://carnegieendowment.org/research/2025/09/climate-backlash-europe-green-transition-farmers-protests - Thalberg, K., Defard, C., Chopin, T., Barbas, A., & Kerneis, K. (2024). <i>The European Green Deal in the face of rising radical right-wing populism</i> (Policy Paper No. 296). Institut Jacques Delors. https://institutdelors.eu/content/uploads/2025/04/PP296_Populisme_Thalberg_EN_2.pdf
Tue 21/4/2026 08:30 -10:00	Enlargement Policy, Coalitions of the Willing and the EU in Wider Europe	Ghincea, M., & Pleşca, L. (2025). From transformation to demarcation: explaining the EU's shifting motivations of the enlargement policy. <i>Journal of European Public Policy</i> , 32(12), 2999–3033.

Tue 21/4/2026 10:15 – 11:45	Introduction to European Foreign, Security and Defense Policy: Actors and Policy Making	Keukeleire, Stephan, and Tom Delreux. “The EU Foreign Policy System: Actors.” In <i>The Foreign Policy of the European Union</i> , 77-116. London: Bloomsbury, 2022. Keukeleire, Stephan, and Tom Delreux. “The EU Foreign Policy System: Policy Making.” In <i>The Foreign Policy of the European Union</i> , 117-137. London: Bloomsbury, 2022.
Thu 30/4/2026 08:30 -10:00	The United States: The Structural Trends Beyond the Current Administration	Simón, L., Desmaele, L., & Becker, J. (2021). Europe as a Secondary Theater? Competition with China and the Future of America’s European Strategy. <i>Strategic Studies Quarterly</i> , 15(1), 90–115. https://www.jstor.org/stable/26984769
Thu 30/4/2026 10:15 – 11:45	Case Study: The Future of NATO and European Security Architecture	Indicative preparation material: • North Atlantic Treaty Organization. (2022). <i>NATO 2022 Strategic Concept</i> (Adopted by Heads of State and Government at the NATO Summit, Madrid, 29 June 2022). https://www.nato.int/en/about-us/official-texts-and-resources/strategic-concepts/nato-2022-strategic-concept.html • Byman, D. (2024, July 12). <i>NATO and countering hybrid warfare</i>. Center for Strategic and International Studies (CSIS). https://www.csis.org/analysis/nato-and-countering-hybrid-warfare • EUdebatesTVLIVE. (2026, Month Day). <i>Andrius Kubilius on defence readiness, unity & fighting as EU!</i> [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=j4CbkJTJlv0 • Kubilius, A. (2026, January 27). <i>On “Europeanization” of European conventional defence: The case for a European Security Council</i> (PDF). https://andriuskubilius.lt/wp-content/uploads/2026/01/AKubilius-on-europeanization-of-european-conventional-defence.pdf
Tue 5 /5/2026 08:30 -10:00	The Rise of China and Great Power Competition	Simón, L., & Fiott, D. (2025). Player and playground: Europe in US–China competition. <i>Journal of European Integration</i> , 47(6), 785–803.
Tue 5 /5/2026 10:15 – 11:45	Case Study: European China Policy	Indicative preparation material: • European Commission & High Representative of the Union for Foreign Affairs and Security Policy. (2019, March 12). <i>EU-China – A strategic outlook: Commission and HR/VP contribution to the European Council</i> (JOIN(2019) 5 final). Publications Office of the European Union. https://commission.europa.eu/system/files/2019-03/communication-eu-china-a-strategic-outlook.pdf • Soong, C. (2025). <i>Art of the struggle meets great power competition: Beijing’s approach to Trump 2.0</i>. Mercator Institute for China Studies (MERICS).

		https://merics.org/en/comment/art-struggle-meets-great-power-competition-beijings-approach-trump-20 ChinaPower. (2025, May 23). <i>Europe's balancing act with China: A conversation with Janka Oertel</i> [Video]. YouTube. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Ik5F6rZuH3o
Fri 8 /5/2026 08:30 -10:00	Europe's Russia Policy After the Full Scale Invasion	Orenstein MA (2023) "The European Union's transformation after Russia's attack on Ukraine" <i>Journal of European Integration</i> , 45(3): 333-342.
Fri 8 /5/2026 10:15 – 11:45	Imagining Europe's Futures	European Commission. (2025). <i>Strategic foresight report 2025</i> . Publications Office of the European Union.